

Taskbar, and Flip. Flip 3D has heavily been touted by Microsoft as one of the major features of Windows Vista: “Windows Flip 3D uses the dimension of visual depth to give you a more comprehensive view of your open windows, helping you sidestep chaos even as you juggle myriad open files and programs. Navigating your desktop has never been this fun.” Yes, fun it is, but it isn’t much else. On hitting the [Windows] + [Tab] keys, Flip 3D kicks into action and organises your open windows into a swanky three-dimensional rolodex.

Now, there are many problems with this approach. It doesn’t let you see the whole contents of any window except the one leading the pack; small windows can sometimes be completely obscured by the larger ones; rolling over any window with the mouse does not give any information about the window; and drag and drop does not work among the windows. To top it off, if the number of open windows exceeds eight, the windows at the back disappear, appearing only on hitting the [Tab] key while simultaneously hiding the first window. The illusion of a 3D pack of windows over a 2D desktop is not a very pleasant one either. All in all, this is a somewhat good idea very poorly implemented.

Compare this to Exposé, which neatly tiles all your windows over the desktop, showing you the full contents of each one and displaying the title of the Windows in distinctly large letters as you roll over them. Pressing [F11] moves all the other windows to the background and fades them and brings all the windows of the currently active application to the front. Pressing [Tab] cycles between the various open applications, and [Command] + [~] cycles through the different windows of the application. It is the best possible way to multi-task.

Flip has been given a nice touch by Microsoft because it now includes live thumbnails when you cycle through the windows. However, as you cycle through the windows, you cannot use any shortcuts to close, maximise, or minimise the windows. You also cannot switch to applications that do not have any windows open